



**A CHILD AND A COUNTRY
AT THE END OF HISTORY**

LEA YPI

FREE

**A CHILD AND A COUNTRY AT
THE
END OF HISTORY**

LEA YPI



W.W. NORTON & COMPANY
Independent Publishers Since 1923

CONTENTS

PART I

- 1 Stalin
- 2 The Other Ypi
- 3 471: A Brief Biography
- 4 Uncle Enver Is Dead
- 5 Coca-Cola Cans
- 6 Comrade Mamuazel
- 7 They Smell of Sun Cream
- 8 Brigatista
- 9 Ahmet Got His Degree
- 10 The End of History

PART II

- 11 Grey Socks
 - 12 A Letter from Athens
 - 13 Everyone Wants to Leave
 - 14 Competitive Games
 - 15 I Always Carried a Knife
 - 16 It's All Part of Civil Society
 - 17 The Crocodile
 - 18 Structural Reforms
 - 19 Don't Cry
 - 20 Like the Rest of Europe
 - 21 1997
 - 22 Philosophers Have Only Interpreted the World; the
Point Is to Change It
- Epilogue

Acknowledgements

STALIN

I NEVER ASKED MYSELF about the meaning of freedom until the day I hugged Stalin. From close up, he was much taller than I expected. Our moral education teacher, Nora, had told us that imperialists and revisionists liked to emphasize how Stalin was a short man. He was, in fact, not as short as Louis XIV, whose height, she said, they—strangely—never brought up. In any case, she added gravely, focusing on appearances rather than what really mattered was a typical imperialist mistake. Stalin was a giant, and his deeds were far more relevant than his physique.

The thing that made Stalin really special, Nora went on to clarify, was that he smiled with his eyes. Can you believe it? Smiling with your eyes? That's because the friendly moustache that adorned his face covered his lips, so that if you focused only on the lips, you would never know if Stalin was really smiling or doing something else. But you just had to take one look at his eyes, piercing, intelligent, and brown, and then you knew. Stalin was smiling. Some people were unable to look you in the eye. They clearly had something to hide. Stalin looked straight at you, and if he felt like it, or if you behaved well, his eyes would smile. He always wore an unassuming coat and plain brown shoes, and he liked to put his right hand under the left side of his coat, as if holding his heart. The left hand, he often kept in his pocket.

"In his pocket?" we asked. "Isn't it rude to walk with your hand in your pocket? Grown-ups always tell us to take our hands out of our pockets."

“Well, yes,” said Nora. “But it is cold in the Soviet Union. And anyway,” she added, “Napoleon also always had his hand in his pocket. Nobody ever said that was rude.”

“Not in his pocket,” I said timidly. “In his waistcoat. In his time, that was a sign of good upbringing.”

Teacher Nora ignored me and was about to take another question.

“*And he was short,*” I interrupted.

“How do you know?”

“My grandmother told me.”

“What did she tell you?”

“She told me that Napoleon was short but when Marx’s teacher Hangel, or Hegel, I can’t remember, saw him, he said one could see the spirit of the world standing on a horse.”

“Hangel,” she corrected. “Hangel was right. Napoleon changed Europe. He spread the political institutions of the Enlightenment. He was one of the greats. But not as great as Stalin. If Marx’s teacher Hangel had seen Stalin standing, obviously not on a horse, but perhaps on a tank, he would have also claimed to have seen the spirit of the world. Stalin was a fundamental source of inspiration for many more people, for millions of our brothers and sisters in Africa and Asia, not only in Europe.”

“Did Stalin love children?” we asked.

“Of course he did.”

“Even more than Lenin?”

“About the same, but his enemies always tried to hide that. They made Stalin sound worse than Lenin because Stalin was stronger and far, far more dangerous for them. Lenin changed Russia, but Stalin changed the world. This is why the fact that Stalin loved children just as much as Lenin was never properly reported.”

“Did Stalin love children as much as Uncle Enver?”

Teacher Nora hesitated.

“Did he love them more?”

“You know the answer,” she said with a warm smile.

IT IS POSSIBLE THAT Stalin loved children. It is likely that children loved Stalin. What is certain, dead certain, is that I never loved him more than on that wet December afternoon when I scampered from the port to the little garden near the Palace of Culture, sweaty, shaky, and with my heart

Certainly, I was regretting it that day. I had chosen freely which way to walk home, and I'd made the wrong decision. I had just finished my cleaning shift in school, after the end of the lessons. We took turns cleaning our classroom in groups of four, but the boys often made excuses and only the girls were left. I shared the shift with my friend Elona. On a normal day, Elona and I would leave the school after cleaning, stop by the old woman who sat on the pavement at the corner of the road selling sunflower seeds, and we would ask her: "Can we try them? Are they salted or unsalted? Roasted or unroasted?" The woman would open one of the three sacks she carried, the roasted and salted one, the roasted and unsalted, the unroasted and unsalted, and we would try a couple of seeds from each. When we had spare coins, there were plenty of choices.

After, we would turn left to go to Elona's house, munching sunflower seeds and struggling a little to let ourselves in with the rusty keys attached to her mother's necklace, which she wore beneath her school uniform. There, we would have to choose which game to play. In December it was easy. At that time of the year preparations for the national song contest started, and we would make up our own songs and pretend we were going to appear on national television. I wrote the lyrics while Elona sang them, and sometimes I offered a drum accompaniment by using a large wooden spoon to beat the pans in the kitchen. Recently, though, Elona had lost interest in Song Contest. She was more likely to want to play Brides and Babies. Instead of beating pans in the kitchen, she wanted us to stay in her parents' room, try out her mother's hair clips, change into her old wedding dress or wear her make-up, and pretend to nurse dolls until it was time for lunch. At that point I would have to decide whether to carry on playing, as Elona wanted, or convince her to fry eggs, or if there were no eggs, whether to eat bread and oil, or perhaps only bread. But these were trivial choices.

The real dilemma emerged after an argument Elona and I had about cleaning the classroom that day. She insisted we ought to both sweep and mop; otherwise we would never get the flag for the best cleaners of the month, which her mother had always been very keen on. I replied that we always swept on odd days of the week, and swept and mopped on even ones, and since it was an odd day, we could go home early and still receive the cleaning flag. She replied that this was not what the teacher expected and reminded me of the time when my parents had been summoned to the school because I had been negligent with my cleaning. I said she was

wrong; the real reason had been the Monday-morning control team, which had discovered that my nails were too long. She maintained that it didn't matter, that in any case the right way to clean the classroom was to both sweep and mop, and even if we did receive the flag at the end of the month, without cleaning the classroom properly, it would feel as if we had cheated. Moreover, she added, as if no further argument could be had, that is how she cleaned at home because that is how her mother used to do it. I told Elona she could not use her mother like that every time just to get her own way. I left in anger, and while standing in the rain by the school gate I wondered if Elona had a right to expect everyone to be nice to her, even when she was wrong. I wondered if I should have pretended that I loved sweeping and mopping just as I pretended that I loved playing Brides and Babies.

I had never told her, but I hated that game. I hated being in her mother's room and trying on the wedding dress. I found it unnerving to wear a dead person's clothes, or to touch the make-up they had been putting on only a few months before, as if we were them. But it was all recent, and Elona had been looking forward to having a baby sister who was going to play with my little brother. Instead, her mother died, the baby sister was sent to the orphanage, and only the wedding dress was left. I did not want to hurt her by refusing to wear it, or to tell her that I was repelled by the hair clips. Of course, I was free to tell her what I thought about Brides and Babies, just as I had been free to leave her to mop the classroom on her own; nobody stopped me. I decided it was better to let Elona hear the truth, even if it might hurt her, than to lie indefinitely just to keep her happy.

If I did not turn left to go to Elona's house, I could turn right. That would have been the shortest route home, following two narrow alleyways that joined the main road in front of a biscuit factory. Here a different dilemma emerged. A sizeable group of children assembled each day after the end of school, at the critical time when the distribution lorry was expected. If I chose that route, I would have to join what we called the "action for biscuits." I would form a line with the other children against the outside walls of the factory, nervously awaiting the arrival of the lorry, monitoring the doors, carefully listening for sounds of potentially disruptive traffic, such as people on bikes or the occasional horse and carriage. At one point, the factory door would open and two transport workers would appear carrying cases of biscuits, like twin Atlases carrying the Earth. There would

be a small commotion, and we would all lurch forward to the chant of “Oh greedy, oh greedy, biscuits, biscuits, oh greedy man!” The orderly line would then spontaneously divide into a vanguard of children in black uniforms waving their arms to try to grab hold of the transport workers’ knees, and a rear guard that swarmed towards the factory gate to obstruct the exit. The workers would twist the lower half of their bodies to release themselves from the hold, while stiffening the upper half so as to tighten their grip on the biscuit cases. A packet would slip, a fight would break out, and then a manager would emerge from inside the factory, holding as many biscuits as necessary to satisfy everyone and triggering the dispersal of the assembly.

I was free to turn right or continue to walk straight, and if I turned right, that is what I could expect to happen. It was all perfectly innocent, and it was unreasonable, possibly unfair, to ask an eleven-year-old who was merely walking back home, without having set out to search for treats, to press ahead, ignoring the delicious smell of biscuits drifting from the factory’s open windows. It would be equally unreasonable to expect her to ignore the awkward, inquisitive looks of the other children by walking past, seemingly indifferent to the arrival of the lorry. Yet that was exactly what my parents had come to ask of me the night before that wretched December day in 1990, which is partly why the decision about which way to walk back home was directly relevant to the question of freedom.

It had been my fault, to some extent. I should never have gone home carrying biscuits like a trophy. But it was also the fault of the new factory manager. Recently hired, she was unaccustomed to the ways of her new workplace and had mistaken the children’s appearance on that day for a one-off event. Instead of offering one biscuit to each child, like all the other managers before her, she had handed over whole packets. Alarmed by this change, and by its implications for the “action for biscuits” in the following days, instead of eating on the spot we had all stored the packets in our school bags and hastily run away.

I confess I did not imagine my parents would kick up such a fuss when I showed them the biscuits and explained where I had found them. I certainly did not expect the first question to be “Did anybody see you?” Of course somebody had seen me, not least the person who had handed over the packets. No, I did not remember her face *exactly*. Yes, she was middle-aged. Not tall, not short, maybe average. Wavy hair, dark. Big, hearty smile. At

that point, my father's face turned pale. He stood up from his armchair, holding his head in his hands. My mother left the living room and made a sign for him to follow her into the kitchen. My grandmother started stroking my hair in silence, and my little brother, to whom I had given a spare biscuit, stopped chewing, sat in a corner, and started crying from the tension.

I was made to promise that I would never linger in the factory yard again or join the line against the wall, and I had to declare that I understood the importance of letting workers carry on with their duties, and how if everyone behaved like me, soon biscuits would disappear from the shops altogether. *Re-ci-pro-ci-ty*, my father emphasized. Socialism is built on reciprocity.

I knew when I made the promise that it would be hard to keep. Or perhaps not—who knows? But I had to at least make the effort in good faith. I did not have anyone to blame for walking straight on, for not going back to collect Elona after the cleaning shift to play Brides and Babies, or for choosing to ignore the biscuits that day. They had all been my decisions. I had done my best and still ended up in the wrong place at the wrong time, and now the result of all that freedom was the sheer terror that the dogs might return to devour me or that I would be crushed in a stampede.

Not that I could have predicted that I would stumble on a protest, or that Stalin would provide shelter. If I had not recently seen scenes of unrest elsewhere on television, I would not even have known that the strange spectacle of people screaming slogans and the police with their dogs was called a “protest.” A few months before, in July 1990, dozens of Albanians had climbed the walls of foreign embassies, forcing themselves inside. I was perplexed as to why anyone might want to lock themselves up in a foreign embassy. We talked about it in school, and Elona said there was once a family, an entire family of six adults, two brothers and four sisters, who had smuggled themselves into the Italian embassy in Tirana dressed as foreign tourists. They lived there for five years—five whole years—in just two rooms. Then another tourist, a real one this time, called Javier Pérez de Cuéllar, visited our country and talked to the embassy climbers, and then to the Party to communicate their desire to live in Italy.

I was intrigued by Elona's story and asked my father what it meant. “They are *uligans*,” he replied, “as they said on TV.” He clarified that *hooligan* was a foreign word for which we had no Albanian translation. We

didn't need it. Hooligans were mostly angry young men who went to football matches, drank too much, and got into trouble, who fought with supporters of the other team and burned flags for no reason. They lived mostly in the West, though there were some in the East too, but since we were neither in the East nor the West, in Albania they hadn't existed until recently.

I thought about hooligans as I tried to make sense of what I had just encountered. Clearly, if one was a hooligan, it would not be beyond the pale to climb up embassy walls, to shout at the police, to disrupt the public order, or to decapitate statues. Clearly, hooligans did the same in the West; perhaps they had smuggled themselves into our country just to provoke trouble. But the people who had climbed the embassy walls a few months before were definitely not foreigners. What did these different hooligans have in common?

I remembered vaguely something called the Berlin Wall protest the year before. We had talked about it in school, and teacher Nora had explained that it was related to the fight between imperialism and revisionism, and how they were each holding a mirror to the other, but both mirrors were broken. None of it concerned us. Our enemies regularly tried to topple our government, but they failed just as regularly. In the late forties, we split up with Yugoslavia when the latter broke with Stalin. In the sixties, when Khrushchev dishonoured Stalin's legacy and accused us of "leftist nationalist deviationism," we interrupted diplomatic relations with the Soviet Union. In the late seventies, we abandoned our alliance with China when the latter decided to become rich and betray the Cultural Revolution. It didn't matter. We were surrounded by powerful foes but knew ourselves to be on the right side of history. Every time our enemies threatened us, the Party, supported by the people, emerged stronger. Throughout the centuries, we had fought mighty empires and shown the rest of the world how even a small nation on the edge of the Balkans could find the strength to resist. Now we were leading the struggle to achieve the most difficult transition: that from Socialist to Communist freedom—from a revolutionary state governed by just laws to the classless society, where the state itself would wither away.

Of course, freedom had a cost, teacher Nora said. We had always defended freedom alone. Now *they* were all paying a price. *They* were in disarray. We were standing strong. We would continue to lead by example.

We had neither money nor weapons, but we continued to resist the siren call of the revisionist East and the imperialist West, and our existence gave hope to all the other small nations whose dignity continued to be trampled on. The honour of belonging to a just society would be matched only by the gratitude felt for being sheltered from the horrors unfolding elsewhere in the world, places where children starved to death, froze in the cold, or were forced to work.

“Have you seen this hand?” teacher Nora had said, lifting up her right hand at the end of the speech with a fierce look on her face. “This hand will always be strong. This hand will always fight. Do you know why? It has shaken Comrade Enver’s hand. I didn’t wash it for days, after the Congress. But even after I washed it, the strength was still there. It will never leave me, never until I die.”

I thought about teacher Nora’s hand, and the words she had spoken to us only a few months ago. I was still sitting on the ground in front of Stalin’s bronze statue, collecting my thoughts, trying to summon the courage to lift myself up and retrace the steps back home. I wanted to remember her every word, to evoke her pride and strength when she’d told us how she was going to defend freedom because she had shaken Uncle Enver’s hand. I wanted to be like her. I must defend my freedom too, I thought. It must be possible to overcome my fear. I had never shaken Uncle Enver’s hand. I had never met him. But maybe Stalin’s legs would be enough to give me strength.

I stood up. I tried to think like my teacher. We had socialism. Socialism gave us freedom. The protesters were mistaken. Nobody was looking for freedom. Everyone was already free, just like me, simply exercising that freedom, or defending it, or making decisions they had to own, about which way to go home, whether to turn right or left or to walk straight. Perhaps also, just like me, they had stumbled near the port by mistake, ending up in the wrong place at the wrong time. Perhaps when they saw the police and the dogs, they were simply very afraid, and the same could be said for the police and the dogs, that they were very afraid in turn, especially when they saw people running. Perhaps both sides were simply chasing each other without knowing who was following whom, and that is why people had started to shout, *Freedom, democracy*, out of fear, and uncertainty, to explain that this was what they did not want to lose, rather than what they wanted.

And perhaps Stalin's head was entirely unrelated. Perhaps it had been damaged in the night by the storm and the rain and someone had already collected it so that it could be repaired and would soon bring it back like new to take its old place, with the sharp, smiley eyes and the thick, friendly moustache covering the upper lip, just as I had been told it looked, just as it had always been.

I hugged Stalin one last time, turned around, stared at the horizon to gauge the distance to my house, took a deep breath, and started to run.

EPILOGUE

EACH YEAR, I BEGIN my Marx courses at the London School of Economics by telling my students that many people think of socialism as a theory of material relations, class struggle, or economic justice but that, in reality, something more fundamental animates it. Socialism, I tell them, is above all a theory of human freedom, of how to think about progress in history, of how we adapt to circumstances but also try to rise above them. Freedom is not sacrificed only when others tell us what to say, where to go, how to behave. A society that claims to enable people to realize their potential but fails to change the structures that prevent everyone from flourishing is also oppressive. And yet, despite all the constraints, we never lose our inner freedom: the freedom to do what is right.

My father and my grandmother did not live to see what became of my studies. After quitting his career as an MP, my father was thrust from one private employer to another, each time blaming the dismissal on his poor English and, increasingly, his rudimentary computer skills. To facilitate his job searches, the family moved to a flat in the capital, close to the old Botanical Gardens, now one of the most polluted areas in the country. His asthma deteriorated. One summer evening, shortly after his sixtieth birthday, he had a violent asthma attack. He rushed to the window and opened it to breathe but was wrapped in a cloud of carbon monoxide and dust. The ambulance found him dead.

My mother was in Italy when it happened. My parents had reconciled, but she worked there seasonally as a carer or cleaner to help offset some of our new debts, while her siblings in Albania chased their old confiscated properties. Those efforts, which Nini had always deemed a “waste of time,” came to fruition a few months after my grandmother’s death, following that of my father. A large chunk of coastal land was sold to an Arab property developer, and our fortunes changed overnight.

I no longer needed to count my last pennies until the next scholarship instalment. I could enjoy meals out and drink late in bars, discussing politics with my new university friends. Many of those friends were self-declared Socialists—Western Socialists, that is. They spoke about Rosa Luxemburg, Leon Trotsky, Salvador Allende, and Ernesto “Che” Guevara as secular saints. It occurred to me that they were like my father in this respect: the only revolutionaries they considered worthy of admiration were the ones that had been murdered. These icons showed up on posters, T-shirts, and coffee cups, much like how photos of Enver Hoxha would show up in people’s living rooms when I was growing up. When I pointed this out, my friends wanted to know more about my country. But they did not think that my stories from the eighties were in any way significant to their political beliefs. Sometimes, my appropriating the label of *Socialist* to describe both my experiences and their commitments was considered a dangerous provocation. We used to go to a large open-air concert in Rome for 1 May, and I could not help but reminisce about the parades of my childhood on Workers’ Day. “What you had was not *really* socialism,” they would say, barely concealing their irritation.

MY STORIES ABOUT SOCIALISM in Albania and references to all the other Socialist countries against which our socialism had measured itself were, at best, tolerated as the embarrassing remarks of a foreigner still learning to integrate. The Soviet Union, China, the German Democratic Republic, Yugoslavia, Vietnam, Cuba—there was nothing Socialist about them either. They were seen as the deserving losers of a historical battle that the real, authentic bearers of that title had yet to join. My friends’ socialism was clear, bright, and in the future. Mine was messy, bloody, and of the past.

And yet, the future they sought, one that Socialist states had once embodied, found inspiration in the same books, the same critiques of society, the same historical characters. But, to my surprise, they treated this as an unfortunate coincidence. Everything that went wrong on my side of the world could be explained by the cruelty of our leaders or the uniquely backward nature of our institutions. They believed there was little for them to learn. There was no risk of repeating the same mistakes, no reason to ponder what had been achieved, and why it had been destroyed. Their socialism was characterized by the triumph of freedom and justice; mine by

the failure of these ideas to be realized. Their socialism would be brought about by the right people, with the right motives, under the right circumstances, with the right combination of theory and practice. There was only one thing to do about mine: forget it.

But I was reluctant to forget. It is not that I felt nostalgic. It is not that I romanticized my childhood. It is not that the concepts I had grown up with were so deeply rooted in me that it was impossible to disentangle myself. But if there was one lesson to take away from the history of my family, and of my country, it was that people never make history under circumstances they choose. It is easy to say, “What you had was not the real thing,” applying that to both socialism and liberalism, to any complex hybrid of ideas and reality. It releases us from the burden of responsibility. We are no longer complicit in moral tragedies created in the name of great ideas, and we don’t have to reflect, apologize, and learn.

“We are doing a reading group on *Das Kapital*,” a friend told me one day. “If you join it, you will learn about real socialism.” And so I did. When I read the opening pages of the preface, it felt a bit like hearing French: a foreign language I had been taught as a child but rarely practised. I remembered many of the keywords—*capitalists, workers, landlords, value, profit*—and they echoed inside my head in the voice and simplified formulations of my teacher Nora, adapted for schoolchildren. Individuals, Marx wrote in the opening pages, “are dealt with only in so far as they are the personifications of economic categories, embodiments of particular class relations and class interests.” But, for me, behind every personification of an economic category, there was the flesh and blood of a real person. Behind the capitalist and the landlord, there were my great-grandfathers; behind the workers, there were the Gypsies who worked at the port; behind the peasants, the people with whom my grandmother was sent to work in the fields when my grandfather went to prison, and about whom she spoke condescendingly. It was impossible to finish reading and just move on.

My mother finds it difficult to understand why I teach and research Marx, why I write essays on the dictatorship of the proletariat. She sometimes reads my articles and finds them baffling. She has learned to weather awkward questions from relatives. Do I really believe these ideas are convincing? Or feasible? How is it possible? Mostly, she keeps her criticisms to herself. Only once did she draw attention to a cousin’s remark

that my grandfather did not spend fifteen years locked up in prison so that I would leave Albania to defend socialism. We both laughed awkwardly, then paused and changed the topic. It left me feeling like someone who is involved in a murder, as if the mere association with the ideas of a system that destroyed so many lives in my family were enough to make me the person responsible for pulling the trigger. Deep down, I knew this was what she thought. I always wanted to clarify, but didn't know where to start. I thought that it would take a book to answer.

This is that book. At first, it was going to be a philosophical book about the overlapping ideas of freedom in the liberal and Socialist traditions. But when I started writing, just like when I started reading *Das Kapital*, ideas turned into people—the people who made me who I am. They loved and fought each other; they had different conceptions of themselves, and of their obligations. They were, as Marx writes, the product of social relations for which they were not responsible, but they still tried to rise above them. They thought they'd succeeded. But when their aspirations became reality, their dreams turned into my disillusionment. We lived in the same place, but in different worlds. These worlds overlapped only briefly, and when they did, we saw things through different eyes. My family equated socialism with denial: the denial of who they wanted to be, of the right to make mistakes and learn from them, to explore the world on one's own terms. I equated liberalism with broken promises, the destruction of solidarity, the right to inherit privilege, selfish enrichment, cultivating illusions while turning a blind eye to injustice.

In some ways, I have gone full circle. When you see a system change once, you start believing that it can change again. Fighting cynicism and political apathy turns into what some might call a moral duty; to me it is more of a debt that I feel I owe to all the people of the past who sacrificed everything because *they* were not apathetic, *they* were not cynical, *they* did not believe that things fall into place if you just let them take their course. If I do nothing, their efforts will have been wasted, their lives will have been meaningless.

My world is as far from freedom as the one my parents tried to escape. Both fall short of that ideal. But their failures took distinctive forms, and without being able to understand them, we will remain divided. I wrote my story to explain, to reconcile, and to continue the struggle.